LESSON 1: THE BASICS

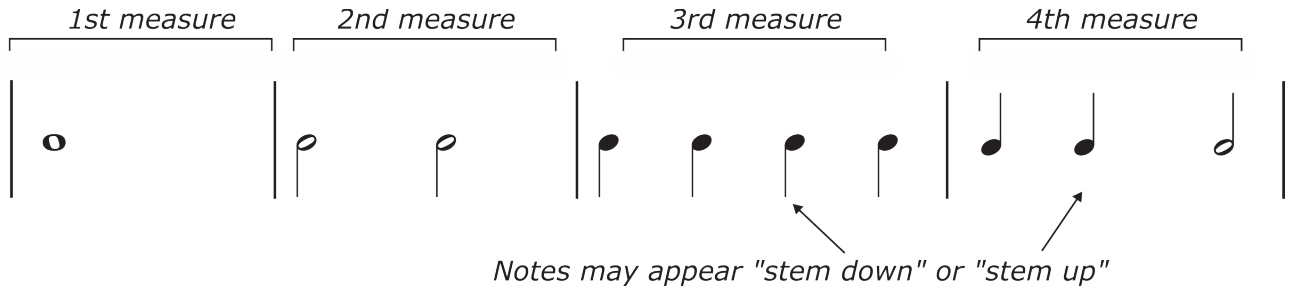
Steady pulses are called **beats**. They can occur quickly (at fast **tempos**) or slowly (at slow tempos). When you set your metronome to a number, that's how many steady pulses it will produce in one minute. This rate is measured in beats-per-minute or **BPM**.

Musical notes that sustain for one beat are called **quarter notes**, those that last two beats are called **half notes**, and those that last four are called **whole notes**. The following symbols are used to denote those values:

Name	*Value*	*Symbol*	*Counts*
Quarter Note	1 beat		1 2 3 4
Half Note	2 beats		1 (2) 3 (4)
Whole Note	4 beats		1 (2 3 4)

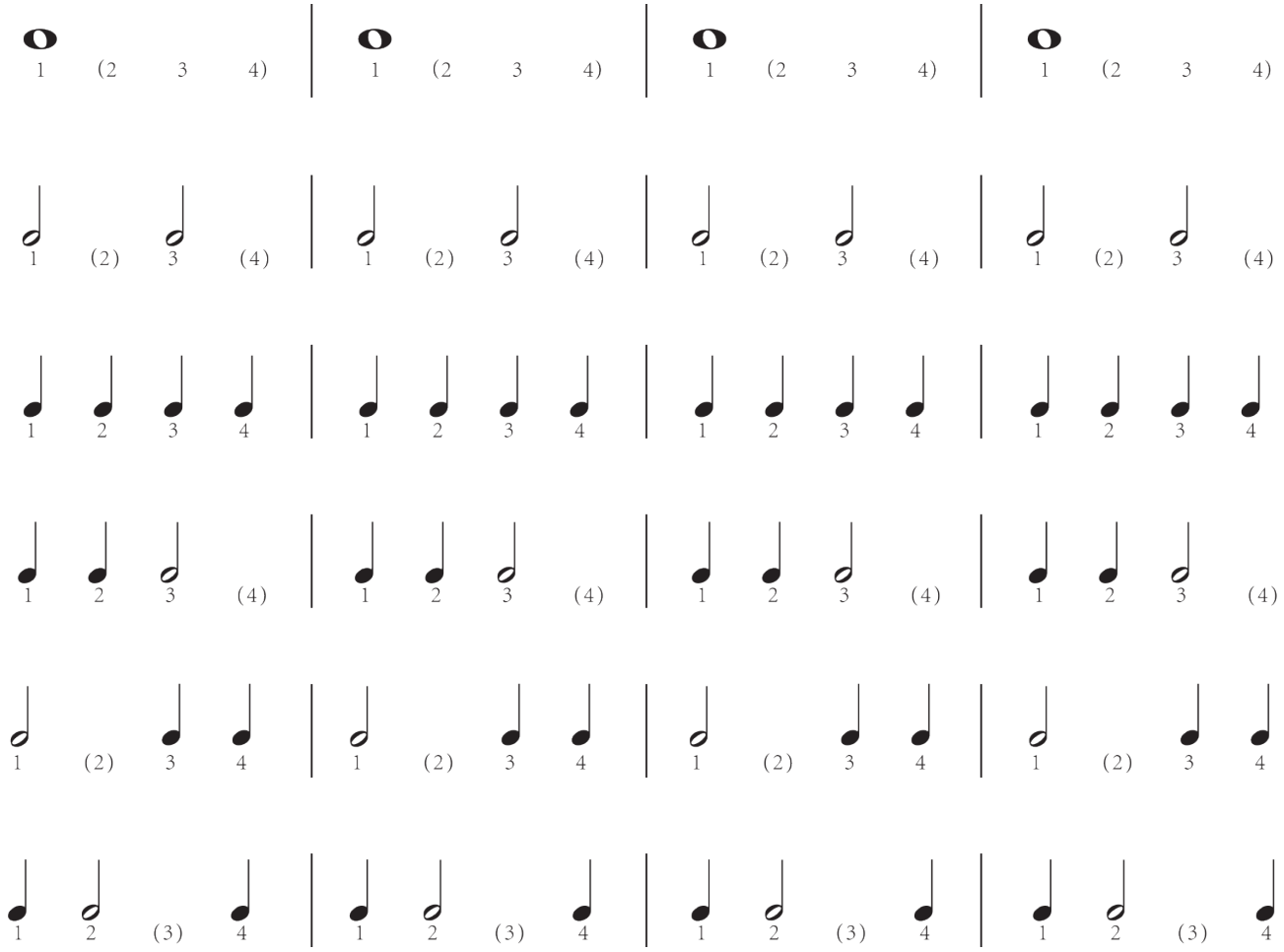
A musical **measure** can be thought of as a container that can hold a certain amount of beats. For our early studies, we'll focus on measures that hold four steady pulses (four beats). Below we see four different measures, with each measure containing just enough space to hold four beats.

Notice how a whole note takes up a whole measure, a half note takes up half of a measure, and a quarter note takes up one-quarter. Also notice how these symbols might appear inverted, which makes no difference to their value.



Exercise (Video #1.1)

On **every single pulse**, tap your foot and count out loud “one, two, three, four.” On beats that aren’t strummed (those written inside parentheses), say those counts quietly but don’t freeze your strumming hand — instead, keep it moving and miss the strings. Only use downstrums.



Advice

Use a light-weight or medium-weight pick (below .90 mm).

Keep your strumming wrist loose and avoid tension.

Angle your pick slightly up toward the ceiling while strumming down.

Ensure your guitar is setup properly and that your action isn’t too high or low.

For all exercises in this book, consider replacing the metronome with a drum-machine.